



COMMON AILMENTS

No medication is 100 percent safe in pregnancy. Don't take any over-the-counter medication, dietary supplement or herbal remedy without checking first with your doctor about its safety during pregnancy.

AILMENT	WHAT DOES IT MEAN FOR MY PREGNANCY?	WHAT CAN I DO?
Flu and common colds	The common cold virus should not affect your baby, but severe flu may increase the risk of low birth weight. Flu can also lead to the more serious bronchitis, or even pneumonia. Colds are dehydrating so keep your fluid levels up.	Keep up your fluid intake, and use steam inhalation and hot, soothing beverages to relieve symptoms (see opposite). If you have a fever, ask your doctor if you can take acetaminophen. (This medication is preferable to ibuprofen or codeine). If you have flu symptoms, see your doctor, who may give you medicine to help shorten the duration of it.
Fever	A high temperature can affect your blood circulation so you should try to bring the fever down. Fever usually indicates a viral or bacterial infection.	Use a sponge dipped in cold water, cold compress, or ice bath to bring down your temperature. You can take acetaminophen if your doctor says it's okay—but do not exceed the maximum daily dosage stated on the box. Call your doctor if your temperature is more than 104° F (40° C).
Ear, throat, chest, or urinary tract infection	Severe bacterial infection can cross the placental barrier and affect your baby so it is important to see your doctor to get any infection treated.	Drink plenty of fluids, and see your doctor. Many antibiotics are safe in pregnancy, but they must be prescribed. He or she may do tests (saliva, or urine for example) to check which antibiotic would be most suitable. Take acetaminophen, if your doctor allows, to reduce the fever.
Diarrhea	Diarrhea will not harm your baby, but you must avoid dehydration. If your diarrhea is combined with vomiting or fever, speak to your doctor.	Diarrhea will usually stop on its own once your body has expelled the infection. Don't take diarrhea medication unless it is prescribed by your doctor. Rehydration solutions are safe to take, but consult your pharmacist first.
Food poisoning	The bacteria that cause food poisoning can be potentially harmful to your baby. The most dangerous of these is listeria, which can cause blood poisoning, meningitis, and pneumonia.	Let your doctor know if you suspect food poisoning and you will be advised on what, if anything, you can take to ease the symptoms. It is important to keep sipping water so that you don't become dehydrated. If you suspect listeriosis, seek help right away.
Pain	Backaches can be quite common in pregnancy, especially in the third trimester. Headache, muscular pain, and back pain will not affect your baby.	Ice and warm compresses can help muscular pain and sprains and back pain respectively, but see your doctor for persistent headaches. You can take acetaminophen if your doctor allows, but don't exceed the maximum daily dosage. Do not take ibuprofen or codeine.
Insomnia	Insomnia is quite common in pregnancy but can stem from a variety of causes. It should not affect your baby, but will be very tiring for you.	Consult your doctor to identify the causes and discuss steps you can take. Do not use any herbal remedies, aromatherapy, or medication to induce sleep without seeking advice first.
Hayfever	While hayfever does not affect your baby, treatment of it can. Always seek advice from your doctor before taking any form of antihistamine.	See your doctor. Some antihistamines are fine to use in pregnancy, but it is likely that you'll be advised to use them in the form of a nasal spray or eye drops rather than pills.
Fungal infections (such as athlete's foot)	Fungal infections such as athlete's foot or yeast have no effect on your unborn baby, but treatments for them can.	Keep the affected area clean, dry, and well-aired. Your doctor will want to see you to prescribe the right (pregnancy-friendly) medication for your situation. Not all OTC fungal treatments are safe in pregnancy. Speak to your doctor.
Itchy skin	Dry, itchy skin complaints can occur for a number of reasons, including eczema and pregnancy-induced pruritis gravidarum, which can be severe.	You can use emollients and water-based creams, which are available over the counter, but you should not use steroidal creams. Ask a pharmacist which are the safest options, or speak to your doctor.
Rashes	Rashes can be concentrated in one area (localized), or all over (generalized). Some rashes are harmless, but you should get them checked to find out the cause.	Ask your doctor to check your rash. If any rash (whether local or generalized) persists for more than 48 hours, see your doctor. You can use calamine lotion to relieve the symptoms of localized rashes, but not generalized ones. Cold water and ice can also help.
Cuts and scrapes	A minor cut or scrape will not harm your baby, but take the usual steps to keep the wound clean and free from infection.	Clean the wound using an antiseptic and keep it dry. Although antiseptics are not thought to be hazardous to pregnancy, check with your pharmacist for the safest options to use.
Head lice	Head lice are annoying for you, but luckily don't pose a threat to your unborn baby.	Tackle the problem first with a head-lice comb. Use the comb on wet hair; repeat every three days to keep clearing young lice as they hatch. You can get 4 percent dimethicone lotion over the counter, but always let the pharmacist know you are pregnant first.
Pinworms	Pinworm infection is not known to put your unborn baby at risk, but treatment for it can.	OTC treatments are not advised when you are pregnant, but strict hygiene measures can treat the pinworms (they have a life cycle of six weeks). See your doctor for advice.